

Case Study: Job Churn Among Foreign-Born Workers in Sweden

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Summary

Foreign-born employees in Sweden are consistently more likely to be new in their job than Swedish-born employees. In every year from 1997 to 2025, a larger share of foreign-born employees had started their current job within the past 12 months. In 2025 the shares were 19.4% and 14.1%, about 1.4 times as high.

The gap rose in the late 2010s and has narrowed since, while both groups move up and down with the economy. For employers, this points to the first year of employment as the period where retention efforts matter most. I analyzed 29 years of EU Labour Force Survey data from Eurostat using SQL (SQLite) and Tableau.

Ask

Business task: Understand whether foreign-born workers in Sweden change jobs more often than Swedish-born workers, how that has changed over time, and what it means for employers' retention and onboarding.

Scenario: The people team at a mid-sized Swedish company is designing an inclusive onboarding program. Many recent hires were born outside Sweden, and the team wants to know whether these employees tend to start from a less established position in the job market, so the program can support them through their first year.

Stakeholders: Human resources, managers, and directors.

Guiding questions:

1. Are foreign-born employees more often in the first year of a job than Swedish-born employees?
2. Has that difference grown, shrunk or stayed stable since 1997?
3. Do both groups respond to economic changes in the same way?

Prepare

I used Eurostat dataset, **lfsa_enewasc**, the share of employed persons who have been in their current job for 12 months or less, by country of birth. It comes from the EU Labour Force Survey, which Statistics Sweden carries out monthly by telephone with a random sample drawn from the population register.

Why this data is credible (ROCCC):

- **Reliable:** official statistics, collected under EU regulation with harmonized definitions
- **Original:** published directly by Eurostat from national survey data
- **Comprehensive:** annual data for Sweden from 1997 to 2025, split by country of birth, age and professional status
- **Current:** includes 2025
- **Cited:** documented in Eurostat and Statistics Sweden metadata

Country of birth comes from Sweden's population register rather than self-reporting, and it's used in the survey weighting, which strengthens the comparison between groups.

License: Eurostat data may be reused with attribution. Source: Eurostat, dataset, ifsa_enewasc.

Data format: SDMX, where each row is one observation (a value for one country, year and group), with a flag column for data quality notes.

Process

Tools: SQLite (DB Browser for SQLite) for cleaning and analysis; Tableau Public for visualization.

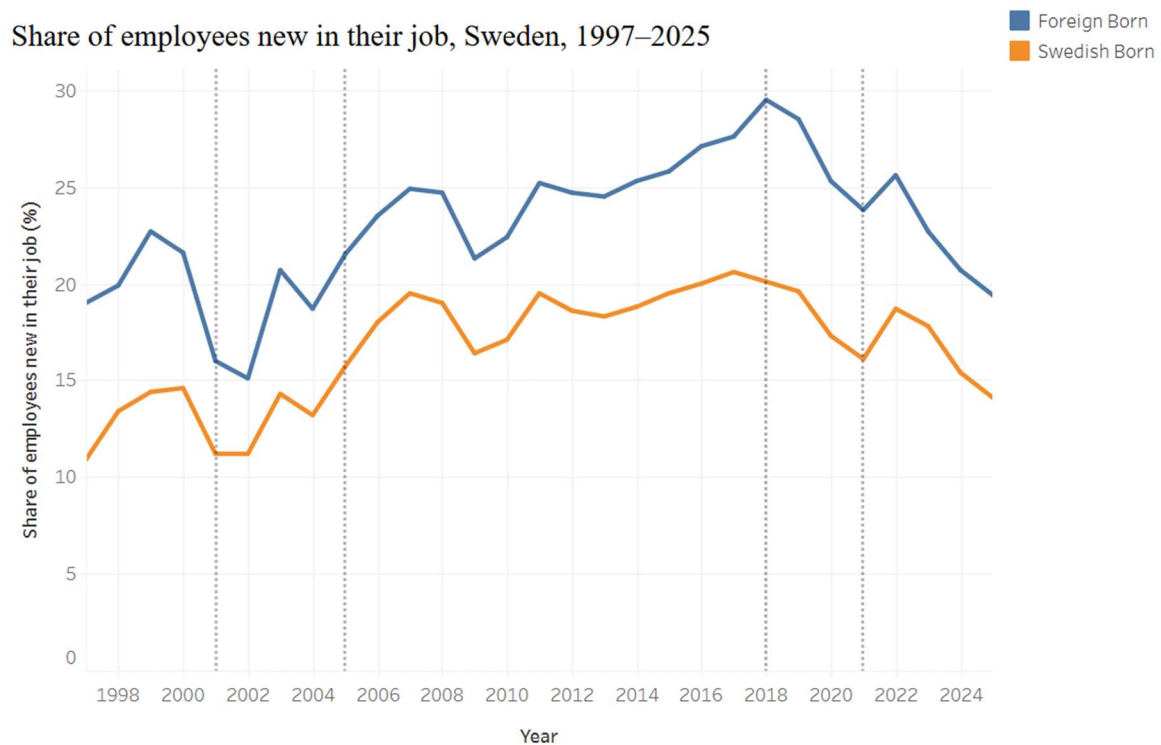
Cleaning steps:

1. Imported the raw CSV into a SQLite database and kept it unchanged; all cleaning happened in new tables.
2. Filtered to Sweden, employees only (excluding self-employed and family workers), ages 20–64, and two groups: Swedish-born ("Reporting country") and foreign-born ("Foreign country").
3. Converted the value column from text to numbers with `CAST(... AS REAL)` so it sorts and calculates correctly.
4. Renamed columns to readable names (year, birth_group, newly_employed_pct, flag).
5. Verified the result: 58 rows (29 years × 2 groups), no missing values, and no low-reliability flags.
6. Reshaped the data to one row per year with both groups side by side, and added a gap column (foreign-born minus Swedish-born).

Data quality checks: I kept the flag column to track years where the survey method changed (2001, 2005, 2018 and 2021). I reviewed Eurostat and Statistics Sweden metadata to understand these changes.

All SQL is documented in two commented files: 01_clean_churn.sql and 02_churn_by_year.sql.

Analyze and Share

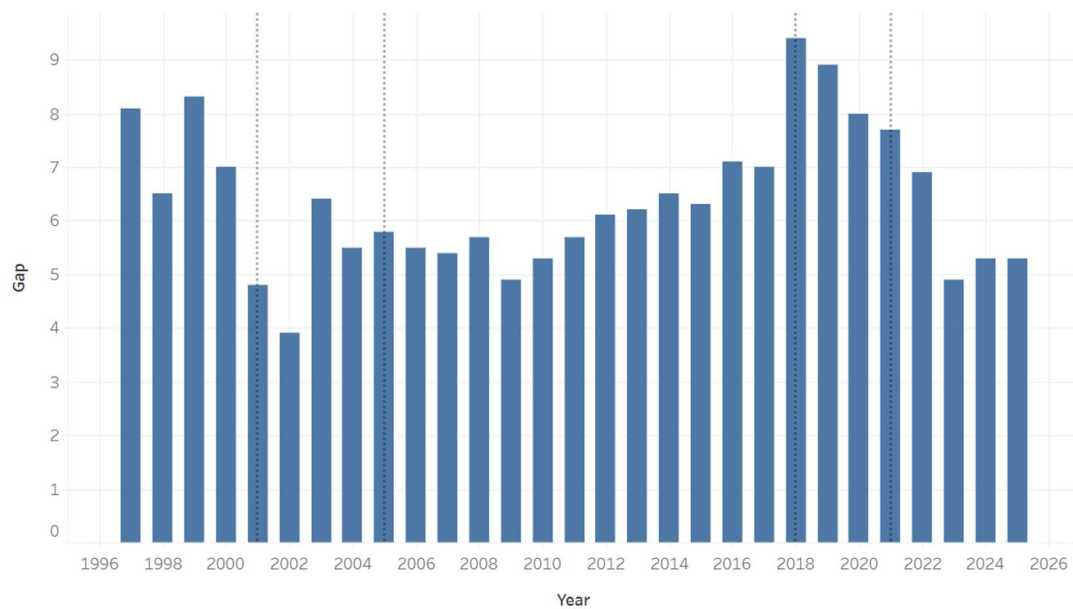


The trends of Foreign Born and Swedish Born for Year. Color shows details about Foreign Born and Swedish Born.

Finding 1: The difference is persistent. A larger share of foreign-born employees were in the first year of their job in all 29 years. The gap ranged from 3.9 percentage points (2002) to 9.4 (2018).

Finding 2: Both groups move with the economy. Both shares fell in 2009 (financial crisis) and 2020 (COVID), and both declined from 2022 to 2025 as the job market weakened. When fewer jobs are available, people stay put and employers hire less.

Foreign-born workers are more often new in their job, every year since 1997



Gap = foreign-born share minus Swedish-born share. Dotted lines mark changes in survey method.

Finding 3: The gap widened, then narrowed. Within 2005–2017, the longest stretch measured the same way, the gap rose from about 5.5 to 7 points. It reached 8–9 points in 2018–2020, then narrowed to about 5 points by 2023–2025.

Interpreting the late-2010s rise: one possible explanation is that many people who arrived in Sweden in 2015–2016 were entering their first jobs around 2017–2019. 2018 is also a survey-change year, so part of that jump may come from the method. This data can't separate the two.

What the measure captures: "new in their job" includes people who changed jobs, people entering work for the first time, and people starting their first job after moving to Sweden. The higher foreign-born share reflects all of these, so it describes where people are in their working life in Sweden, not whether they chose to leave. The data doesn't show why anyone changed jobs.

Act

The first year of a job is when employees are least established, and foreign-born employees are more often in that position. Under Sweden's Discrimination Act, employers can't target programs by national or ethnic origin, so each option below applies to all new hires. Employees who are newest to the Swedish job market are likely to benefit most.

Option	What it involves	Pros	Cons
1. Structured first-year onboarding	Mentor or buddy for every new hire, check-ins at 30, 90 and 180 days, clear introduction to workplace norms and unwritten rules	Low cost; helps every new hire settle in and succeed	Results take a year or more to show; depends on managers following through
2. Clearer paths from temporary to permanent contracts	Review temporary contracts at a set point, with transparent criteria for moving to a permanent role	Gives new hires security and a visible future at the company	Less staffing flexibility; higher fixed costs
3. Listen to new hires in their first year	Short new-hire surveys at 3 and 12 months, plus 12-month retention, reported in aggregate by department and role	Shows where new hires feel supported and where they don't; evidence for later decisions	Needs clean HRIS data; must comply with GDPR, so no sensitive personal data without a clear legal basis

Recommendation: start with options 3 and 1 together. Listening to new hires shows where the first year works well and where it doesn't. A structured onboarding program then strengthens those points, benefits every new hire, and costs little. Option 2 can follow if new hires say contract uncertainty is a concern.

Who and when: HR analytics sets up the new-hire surveys and retention measure within one quarter. HR business partners and people managers launch the onboarding program in the following quarter, with a first review after 12 months.

Limitations

- Survey method changes: the method changed in 2001, 2005, 2018 and 2021, so part of any jump in those years may reflect the method rather than real change. These years are marked on the charts.
- Turnover vs. entry: the measure can't separate people who switched jobs from people entering work for the first time.
- Definition of foreign-born: someone who moved to Sweden at age 2 is grouped with adults who arrived looking for work. Public tables don't show age at arrival.
- Residence permits: people without a residence permit, such as asylum seekers awaiting a decision, aren't in the population register or the survey.

- National averages: the data describes Sweden as a whole, not any single employer, and can't explain why individuals changed jobs.

Conclusion and next steps

For almost three decades, foreign-born employees in Sweden have been more often in the first year of a job than Swedish-born employees, in good and bad economic years alike. That makes the first year the clearest place for employers to help. Listening to new hires and investing in structured onboarding for everyone supports people who are newest to the Swedish job market without singling out any group.

Next steps for further analysis:

- Add temporary-contract data (Eurostat `lfsa_eegatm`, 2021–2025) to test whether contract type helps explain the gap.
- Use Statistics Sweden's MONA microdata, available to approved researchers, to separate people who arrived as children from those who arrived as adults.
- Repeat the analysis inside an organization using HRIS data on 12-month retention, to see whether the national pattern holds locally.

What I learned: working with official statistics means reading the metadata as carefully as the data. The survey-change flags and coverage rules shaped how I could interpret every trend.